Guardrail and Falling Object Protection Checklist (29 CFR 1910.29)

Use when guardrails, stairs, hole covers, warning lines or toeboards are installed, changed or inspected on site.

OSHA 29 CFR 1910.29

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A; use N/A only where that system is not used at the location.
2. For any Defect, record the location, keep employees from the work that needs that protection until it is fixed (1910.29(a)(2) requires protection before such work begins), and re-check after repair.
3. The manufacturer's instructions and site rules may add checks; the strength, load and fixed-ladder criteria are in the full text of 29 CFR 1910.29.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1910.29: Fall protection systems and falling object protection—criteria and practices (Part 1910 Subpart D: Walking-Working Surfaces)
Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09
Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1910-29-fall-protection-systems-falling-object

SECTION A | Guardrail systems

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Top rail height Ref. 1910.29(b)(1)	Top edge measures 42 inches, within 3 inches either way, above the walking surface at several points; if higher than 45 inches, every other paragraph (b) criterion is still met.	☐	☐	☐	
2	Midrail position Ref. 1910.29(b)(2)(i)	Midrail sits halfway between the top edge and the surface wherever no wall or parapet of 21 inches or more is present.	☐	☐	☐	
3	Screens and mesh Ref. 1910.29(b)(2)(ii)	Screen or mesh fills the space from floor level to top rail across the full width between supports.	☐	☐	☐	
4	Balusters and vertical members Ref. 1910.29(b)(2)(iii)	Gaps between balusters or other vertical members are 19 inches or less.	☐	☐	☐	
5	Other intermediate members Ref. 1910.29(b)(2)(iv)	Openings left by additional midrails, architectural panels or other equivalent members are no more than 19 inches wide.	☐	☐	☐	
6	Rail surfaces Ref. 1910.29(b)(6)	Rails are smooth, with no burrs, splinters or sharp edges that could cut skin or snag clothing.	☐	☐	☐	
7	Rail ends Ref. 1910.29(b)(7)	Top rail and midrail ends stop at the terminal posts or, if they overhang, create no projection hazard.	☐	☐	☐	
8	Rail material Ref. 1910.29(b)(8)	No steel or plastic banding is used as a top rail or midrail.	☐	☐	☐	
9	Rail size Ref. 1910.29(b)(9)	Top rails and midrails are at least 0.25 inch in diameter or thickness.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION A | Guardrail systems

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
10	Rope rails Ref. 1910.29(b)(15)	Manila or synthetic rope rails are inspected as often as needed and still meet the strength required by paragraphs (b)(3) and (b)(5).	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION B | Hoist areas, holes and ramps

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
11	Hoist area opening Ref. 1910.29(b)(10)	When no hoisting is happening, a removable section with upper and middle rails closes the access opening, or chains or gates the employer has shown to be equivalent.	☐	☐	☐	
12	Guardrails around holes Ref. 1910.29(b)(11)	Rails stand on every open side or edge of the hole.	☐	☐	☐	
13	Holes while passing materials Ref. 1910.29(b)(12)(i)	Only one or two guardrail sides are open while materials go through.	☐	☐	☐	
14	Holes when not passing materials Ref. 1910.29(b)(12)(ii)	Rails are back on every open side, or a cover closes the hole.	☐	☐	☐	
15	Ladderway gate Ref. 1910.29(b)(13)(i)	Self-closing gate slides or swings away from the hole and carries upper and middle rails or an equivalent member.	☐	☐	☐	
16	Offset ladderway opening Ref. 1910.29(b)(13)(ii)	Where no gate is fitted, the opening is offset so no one can walk or fall straight into the hole.	☐	☐	☐	
17	Ramps and runways Ref. 1910.29(b)(14)	Every open side or edge of each ramp and runway is guarded.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Hole covers and designated areas

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
18	Hole cover capacity Ref. 1910.29(e)(1)	Cover can support at least double the heaviest load that may be on it at one time.	☐	☐	☐	
19	Hole cover secured Ref. 1910.29(e)(2)	Cover is secured so it cannot be accidentally displaced.	☐	☐	☐	
20	Employees inside the area Ref. 1910.29(d)(1)(i)	Employees stay within the designated area while work is under way.	☐	☐	☐	
21	Perimeter marked Ref. 1910.29(d)(1)(ii)	The area's perimeter is marked with a warning line of rope, wire, tape or chain.	☐	☐	☐	
22	Warning line height Ref. 1910.29(d)(2)(ii)	Lowest point of the line, sag included, is 34 to 39 inches above the surface.	☐	☐	☐	
23	Warning line support Ref. 1910.29(d)(2)(iii)	Pulling on one section does not take up slack in neighbouring sections and drop the line below 34 inches.	☐	☐	☐	
24	Warning line visibility Ref. 1910.29(d)(2)(iv)	Line can be clearly seen from 25 feet away and from every spot inside the area.	☐	☐	☐	
25	Warning line placement Ref. 1910.29(d)(2)(v)	Line is as close to the work area as the task permits.	☐	☐	☐	

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SECTION C | Hole covers and designated areas

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
26	Warning line setback Ref. 1910.29(d)(2)(vi)	Line is 6 feet or more from the roof edge for temporary and infrequent work, 15 feet or more for other work; see the next item where mobile mechanical equipment is used.	☐	☐	☐	
27	Setback with mobile equipment Ref. 1910.29(d)(3)	Where mobile mechanical equipment does temporary and infrequent work, line is 6 feet or more from an unprotected edge parallel to the direction the equipment is operated and 10 feet or more from one perpendicular to it.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Handrails and stair rails

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
28	Handrail height Ref. 1910.29(f)(1)(i)	Handrail top is 30 to 38 inches above the front edge of the tread.	☐	☐	☐	
29	Stair rail height, newer stairs Ref. 1910.29(f)(1)(ii)(B)	Stair rail installed on or after January 17, 2017 is 42 inches or higher, measured from the front edge of the tread.	☐	☐	☐	
30	Stair rail height, older stairs Ref. 1910.29(f)(1)(ii)(A)	Stair rail installed before January 17, 2017 is 30 inches or higher.	☐	☐	☐	
31	Top rail used as handrail Ref. 1910.29(f)(1)(iii)	Where the stair rail's upper rail also serves as the handrail, it is 36 to 38 inches high and meets the other handrail rules in paragraph (f).	☐	☐	☐	
32	Finger clearance Ref. 1910.29(f)(2)	At least 2.25 inches between the handrail and any wall or other object.	☐	☐	☐	
33	Stair rail openings Ref. 1910.29(f)(4)	No gap in the stair rail measures over 19 inches in its smallest direction.	☐	☐	☐	
34	Grip Ref. 1910.29(f)(5)	Handrail can be firmly grasped along its length.	☐	☐	☐	
35	Rail surfaces Ref. 1910.29(f)(3)	Handrails and stair rails are smooth, with nothing that could puncture skin or catch clothing.	☐	☐	☐	
36	Rail ends Ref. 1910.29(f)(6)	Handrail and stair rail ends do not stick out where someone could strike them.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION E | Falling object protection

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
37	Toeboard coverage Ref. 1910.29(k)(1)(i)	Toeboard runs along the exposed overhead edge far enough to shield everyone working beneath.	☐	☐	☐	
38	Toeboard height Ref. 1910.29(k)(1)(ii)	Top edge is 3.5 inches or more above the surface.	☐	☐	☐	
39	Gap under toeboard Ref. 1910.29(k)(1)(iii)	Clearance between the toeboard and the surface is 0.25 inch or less.	☐	☐	☐	
40	Toeboard openings Ref. 1910.29(k)(1)(iv)	Toeboard is solid, or no hole in it is bigger than 1 inch in any direction.	☐	☐	☐	

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SECTION E | Falling object protection

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
41	Pit toeboards Ref. 1910.29(k)(1)(v)	Around vehicle repair, service or assembly pits, toeboard is 2.5 inches or higher, unless the employer has shown it would block access to a vehicle over the pit.	☐	☐	☐	
42	Stacked items Ref. 1910.29(k)(2)(i)	Where items are piled above the toeboard, paneling or screening reaches the midrail, and reaches the upper rail if items rise above the midrail.	☐	☐	☐	
43	Guardrail openings Ref. 1910.29(k)(2)(ii)	Openings are small enough that tools and materials cannot fall through.	☐	☐	☐	
44	Canopies Ref. 1910.29(k)(3)	Canopy is strong enough not to collapse or be pierced by falling objects.	☐	☐	☐	

DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE? ☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE	DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW	DATE / TIME